

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-04-07

To all National Spiritual Assemblies dear Bahá'í

1 Issues Related to the Study of the Bahá'í Faith
2 in May of 1998, Bahá'í Canada reproduced a collection of letters which
3 subject of the academic study of the Bahá'í Faith. Copies of this compilation
4 were subsequently mailed by the Canadian National Spiritual Assembly to
5 its sister Assemblies. The reprint has now been made generally available in booklet
form by the United States Bahá'í Publishing Trust. The House of 295.4

295 5

296 1

297 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

298 Justice has asked us to forward you a copy of the latter publication with the
299 following comments.

300 As a number of the friends are aware, a campaign of internal opposition
301 to the Teachings is currently being carried on through the use of the inter-
302 net, a communications system that now reaches virtually every part of the
303 world. Differing from attacks familiar in the past, it seeks to recast the entire
304 faith into a sociopolitical ideology alien to Bahá'u'lláh's intent. In the place
305 of the institutional authority established by his covenant, it promotes a
306 kind of interpretive authority which those behind it attribute to the views of persons
technically trained in Middle East studies.

307 early in 1996, the deliberate nature of the plan was revealed in an ac-
308 cidental posting to an internet list which Bahá'í subscribers had believed
309 was dedicated to scholarly exploration of the cause. Some of the people
310 responsible resigned from the faith when counselors pointed out to them
311 the direction their activities were taking. A small number of others continue to
promote the campaign within the Bahá'í community.

312 in the past, in situations of a somewhat similar nature, the patience and

compassion shown by ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and the guardian helped various be-

313 lievers who had been misled by ill-intentioned persons to eventually free themselves
from such entanglements. in this same spirit of forbearance the

314 universal house of justice has intervened in the current situation only to

315 the extent that has been unavoidable, trusting to the good sense and the goodwill of
the believers involved to awaken to the spiritual dangers to which they are exposing
themselves. Nevertheless, certain counselors and

316 National Spiritual Assemblies are monitoring the problem closely, and the friends
can be confident that whatever further steps are needed to protect the integrity of the cause
will be taken.

317 As passages in the enclosed reprint make clear, this campaign of internal

318 opposition—while purporting to accept the legitimacy of the guardianship

319 center of his covenant—attempts to cast doubt on the nature and scope of

320 the authority conferred on them in the writings. when other bahá’ís have

321 pointed out that such arguments contradict explicit statements of the mas-

322 ter, persons behind the scheme have responded by calling into question the
soundness of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s own judgment and perspective. gradually, these

323 arguments have exposed the view of those involved that bahá’u’lláh himself

324 was not the voice of god to our age but merely a particularly enlightened

325 moral philosopher, one whose primary concern was to reform existing society.296.2

296 3

296 4

296 5

297 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

298 662by itself, such opposition would likely stand little chance of influencing

299 reasonably informed bahá’ís. As one of the letters in the enclosed reprint

300 (20 july 1997) points out, the scheme relies for effect, therefore, on exploit-

301 ing the confusion created in modern thought by the reigning doctrines of

302 materialism. Although the reality of god’s continuous relationship with his

303 creation and his intervention in human life and history are the very essence

304 of the teachings of the founders of the revealed religions, dogmatic mate-

305 rialism today insists that even the nature of religion itself can be adequately
understood only through the use of an academic methodology designed to ignore the truths
that make religion what it is.

306 in general, the strategy being pursued has been to avoid direct attacks
307 on the faith's central figures. The effort, rather, has been to sow the seeds
308 of doubt among believers about the faith's teachings and institutions by
309 appealing to unexamined prejudices that bahá'ís may have unconsciously
310 absorbed from non-bahá'í society. in defiance of the clear interpretation
311 of 'Abdu'l-bahá and the guardian, for example, bahá'u'lláh's limiting of
312 as merely a "temporary measure" subject to eventual revision if sufficient pressure is
brought to bear. Similarly, Shoghi effendi's explanation of
313 bahá'u'lláh's vision of the future bahá'í world commonwealth that will
314 unite spiritual and civil authority is dismissed in favor of the assertion
315 that the modern political concept of "separation of church and state" is
316 somehow one that bahá'u'lláh intended as a basic principle of the world
317 order he has founded. particularly subtle is an attempt to suggest that the

ma

318 shriqu'l-A dhkár should evolve into a seat of quasi-doctrinal authority,
319 parallel to and essentially independent of the local house of justice, which
320 would permit various interests to insinuate themselves into the direction of the life
processes of the cause.

321 Typically, when misrepresentations of the kind described are challenged,
322 the reaction of those behind the campaign has been to claim that their civil
323 rights are being threatened, an assertion that is of course meaningless in the
324 light of the purely voluntary nature of bahá'í membership. much emphasis
325 is placed by them also on academic freedom, their view of which proves, on
examination, to be merely freedom on their part to pervert scholarly
326 discourse to the promotion of their own ideological agenda, while seeking
327 to exclude from discussion features of the bahá'í faith that are central to the

writings of its founders.296.6

296 7

296 8

297 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

298 66The effect of continued exposure to such insincerity about matters vital

299 to humanity's well-being is spiritually corrosive. when we encounter minds

300 that are closed and hearts that are darkened by evident malice, bahá'u'lláh
301 urges that we leave such persons to god and turn our attention to the op-
302 portunities which multiply daily for the promotion of the truths which he
303 teaches. in words written at the direction of the guardian, regarding a situ-
304 ation similar to, though much less serious than, the present one, “. . . the
305 friends should be advised to just leave these people alone, for their influence

can be nothing but negative and destructive. . . .”296-1

306 The enclosed material is being sent to your Assembly less out of concern
307 over the immediate situation, which is being systematically addressed, than because
of longer-term considerations to which it lends perspective. what
308 we are currently seeing, in a relatively primitive form, is the emergence of a new kind
of internal opposition to bahá'u'lláh's mission. while it will no
309 doubt assume other features as time passes, it is a kind of opposition that takes aim
directly at bahá'u'lláh's assertion of the spiritual nature of reality
310 and of humanity's dependence on the interventions of d ivine r evelation.
311 developments of the kind described will come as no surprise to friends
312 who are familiar with the guardian's description of the successive waves of
313 “crisis” and “victory” that have marked the history of the faith ever since
314 its inception. it is precisely this cyclical process, Shoghi effendi says, that
315 has propelled the steady unfoldment of bahá'u'lláh's intent, testing our

commitment to his Teachings, purifying his community, and releasing a

316 greater measure of the capacities latent in his revelation. That resistance to
317 bahá'u'lláh should now be emerging in yet a new guise is itself a tribute to
318 the gathering strength of the cause, offering the friends everywhere new op-
319 portunities for the deepening of their faith and the energizing of their work.
320 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat

321 296-1. mc, p. 66.296.9

296 10

296 11

297 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

Verdict for Arrest and Imprisonment**of Four Bahá'ís in Iran**

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]